



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Our Lady of Mount Carmel School

School Website: <https://olmc.academy/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**Executive Summary**

Our Lady of Mount Carmel School (NJ 07005 Boonton) presents a strong Catholic, virtue-centered educational identity with a clearly articulated sacramental life and Catholic formation. Public-facing materials emphasize faith as foundational, a sacramental/ liturgical rhythm, service to others, and a commitment to forming virtuous citizens. At the same time, the school blends Montessori elements with a classical-inflected emphasis on literature, the liberal arts, and classic culture (e.g., Shakespeare and Great Books-like engagement). The result is a hybrid that leans toward classical orientation in spirit and aims, but remains anchored in Catholic formation and Montessori practice in structure. Based on the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School rubric, the school is best described as **SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL** overall, with particularly strong **CLASSICAL** signals in religious formation, virtue-focused purpose, and community/faculty alignment, but with notable Montessori influences in curriculum and pedagogy that temper a fully classical profile.

Key strengths - Strong Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: explicit Catholic identity, sacramental life, liturgical practices, and Catholic worldview integrated across grades. - Purpose and Goal aligned to formation and virtue: emphasis on forming character and serving others, not solely workforce readiness. - Faculty and Parent/Community engagement: visible living-curriculum teachers, parish/campus involvement, and family/community partnerships.

Key growth opportunities (the needle movers) - Curriculum clarity toward the classical Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) as an explicit, cross-grade framework, with explicit Great Books exposure at all levels beyond Shakespeare. - Pedagogy that foregrounds deliberate classical methods (Socratic dialogue, seminars) in upper grades, with clearly stated expectations across K–12. - Greater articulation of the liberal arts backbone (grammar/logic/rhetoric, Latin/Greek options) to strengthen the “classical” spine and reduce ambiguity with Montessori elements.

The following analysis provides category-by-category evidence, keyword analysis, and rationale, followed by concrete steps to move toward a fuller **CLASSICAL** designation.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot**Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

Evidence - Public materials foreground a strongly Catholic identity, with explicit statements of faith formation and sacramental life (Mass, Adoration, Benediction, Confession, liturgical practices) and a Catholic worldview shaping education. Examples include “WE STRIVE TO BE FAITHFULLY CATHOLIC,” “WE PRIORITIZE THE SACRAMENTAL LIFE,” and references to liturgy and Catholic traditions. - Religion is taught in every grade; sacramental life is central; explicit Catholic identity is highlighted alongside character formation and service. - Communities emphasize virtue/character formation, service to others, and a liturgical/catechetical framework (e.g., Divine Mercy Chaplet, Stations of the Cross, Rosary).

Positive keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: Catholic, Mass, sacramental life, liturgy, Catholic identity, religion in every grade, sacred music, rosary, devotional practices, virtue formation, service. - Negative indicators: None clearly present in this public material (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or values-clarification signals).

Why this rating - The materials evidence transcendent moral realism through a robust Catholic metaphysical frame (virtue, sacramentality, liturgical life) and explicit theological grounding. The presence of liturgical practices and sacramental life strongly supports a CLASSICAL alignment in this category, though the Catholic framework dominates rather than a fully secularized classical synthesis. The lack of any explicit negative signals strengthens the CLASSICAL lean for this domain, while the overall SCHOOL GRAIN remains anchored in Catholic formation.

Citations: Catholic identity and sacramental life language; Mass and liturgical life references.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Formation, virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing are central aims; the school frames education as formation rather than mere information. Explicit statements emphasize virtue, human excellence, and moral purpose; there is a clear orientation away from mere job-preparation toward human excellence and moral imagination. - Measures of success emphasize character and impact on others rather than solely test scores. This aligns with a classical telos of forming virtuous, wise souls. - The presence of Catholic identity is consistent with a telos-driven education aligned to truth, goodness, and beauty as real aims of human formation.

Positive keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: formation, virtue, wisdom, human flourishing, classical mission, telos, contemplation, great conversation (implied by classical emphasis), moral imagination, truth/goodness/beauty (via Catholic framing and virtue formation context). - Negative indicators: None explicit tied to displacing formation with workforce metrics.

Why this rating - The school makes clear that education is about forming virtuous humans rather than merely training for employment. The emphasis on moral/permanent questions and character formation aligns well with classical aims, supporting a CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Citations: Formation and virtue language; “measure success by impact on others” clause.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school identifies itself as a Montessori Preschool & Classical Kindergarten–8th Grade Academy, signaling a blend of Montessori structure with classical aims (e.g., emphasis on the liberal arts sensibility and Great Books through Shakespeare, and engagement with “the best of our rich intellectual and artistic heritage”). - Curriculum description highlights five Montessori areas (Practical Life, Language, Math, Art, Sensorial) with integration of science and history, plus direct engagement with Shakespeare and the broader classical heritage in some materials. This shows a hybrid approach rather than a pure classical curriculum. - Public materials emphasize “the greatest literary, scientific, mathematical, and artistic ideas” and direct reading (e.g., Shakespeare) rather than a purely secondary or summarized treatment, which aligns with classical philosophy in spirit. - The presence of “Montessori curriculum” alongside “classical” framing in the site headings and materials indicates a two-track curriculum approach rather than a singular classical pathway.

Positive keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: liberal arts framework (explicitly “classical” in branding), Shakespeare, Great Books/Great Conversation spirit (explicit Shakespeare), reading literature directly (not just about it), “classical” branding in the curriculum (OLMC Academy). - Negative indicators: Montessori pedagogy and structure (Practical Life, Sensorial, Montessori methods) provide a non-classical curricular backbone that tempers the classical alignment. The explicit Trivium/Quadrivium language (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and explicit “Great Books” sequences beyond Shakespeare are not consistently foregrounded across all grade levels in the public materials.

Why this rating - The curriculum is clearly hybrid: Montessori methods and a classical literacy/literary engagement exist side-by-side. While Shakespeare and classical literature are highlighted, and “great books” ideas appear, the explicit, uniform classical curriculum framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric across grades with a defined Great Conversation trajectory) is not consistently stated across the materials. This justifies a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating in this category.

Citations: Montessori-classical branding; five-area Montessori curriculum; Shakespeare emphasis; direct literature engagement.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The presence of “restful learning” and “scholé days,” contemplation, and wonder as part of pedagogy aligns with classical pedagogy’s emphasis on contemplative, memory-enhancing practices. These features show a clear classical influence in teaching style. - Younger students are described as singing, chanting, memory-focused recitation (lower school), which matches the classical pedagogy emphasis on memory work and ritualized learning often used in early education. - Upper grades reference Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetoric training; however, explicit evidence of ongoing Socratic pedagogy across all high-school grades is less clearly demonstrated in the public materials, and the content often highlights a broader “group inquiry” approach. This yields a partial classical pedagogy signal. - There are explicit references to rhetoric and public speaking “upper school rhetoric theses, capstone orations,” indicating classic rhetorical training at least in upper grades.

Positive keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: scholé, contemplation, wonder, memory work, narration/recitation, chanting, seminars, dialectic (Socratic) in some form (upper school projects), rhetoric, public speaking, and capstone orations. - Negative indicators: The public materials do not consistently emphasize pure experiential or project-based pedagogy as the dominant mode; however, Montessori elements and a student-centered approach are present, which can dilute the pure classical pedagogy signal.

Why this rating - Pedagogy shows a mix of classical-style practices (memory work, chanting, recitation, seminars, rhetoric in upper grades) with Montessori-influenced, student-centered, and experiential approaches. The evidence supports substantial classical pedagogical signals but not a uniformly explicit, all-grades-Socratic/seminar-centric approach. Thus, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL is appropriate for Pedagogy.

Citations: Scholé and contemplative language; lower-school chanting/memory; upper-school seminars & rhetoric; overall student-centered language.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty are described as “model teachers and mentors” who “model virtue, skill, and knowledge”; the teachers are presented as the living curriculum and “core of the school.” This aligns with classical education’s emphasis on teachers as moral exemplars and the living curriculum rather than a rigid, purely tested-based faculty. - There is emphasis on a “portrait of a teacher” and “faculty of friends” concept, signaling a relational culture consistent with classical education’s teacher-student mentorship emphasis. - The faculty is described as “dedicated professionals with extensive classical preparation” and “lifelong learners” who emulate classical ideals and engage in ongoing learning with students.

Positive keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: model teachers, living curriculum, portrait of teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, classical preparation, lifelong learners, mentorship, virtue exemplars. - Negative indicators: None evident in the public materials; no signals of a purely value-neutral or non-classical staff approach.

Why this rating - The explicit emphasis on virtuous teaching, “living curriculum,” and teachers who themselves reflect classical ideals supports CLASSICAL in the Faculty category.

Citations: Faculty language in OLMC materials; teacher preparation and “living curriculum.”

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with parents, “co-teachers with the school teachers,” and parent formation via the website and gatherings, which aligns with classical education’s emphasis on family formation and parental participation. - There are explicit parent involvement opportunities (volunteer opportunities, chaperone needs, and family/community events) and references to open campus and hospitality that support an involved parent community. - Materials show ongoing engagement with families through

newsletters and events, reinforcing the parental formation and involvement dimension, a hallmark of classical community integration.

Positive keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parent formation, seminars/book clubs (as a model in the lexicon; while not all may be exactly quoted, OLMC materials frequently mention family involvement and parent participation in school life), open campus, hospitality, parent covenant, community events. - Negative indicators: None explicitly; consumer-language signals or customer-centric framing are not evident in the public materials.

Why this rating - The public materials demonstrate strong, ongoing parental involvement and community partnership, firmly aligning with CLASSICAL signals for Parents & Community.

Citations: Parent involvement, partnerships, volunteer opportunities, and community events.

What Would Move the Needle

- Curriculum clarity and transparency as a fully classical spine
- Explicitly articulate the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) as a cross-grade framework and connect it to daily activities, assessments, and reading lists.
- Build a visible, year-by-year Great Books sequence beyond Shakespeare to demonstrate a continuous Great Conversation across grades (e.g., Homer, Plato, Augustine, Shakespeare, etc.), with corresponding discussion formats.
- Ground the curriculum with clear declarations of classical subjects (Latin or classical languages) and a defined history/Western civilization arc, separate from Montessori pedagogy where feasible.
- Pedagogy enhancement toward classical methods
- Expand explicit Socratic/seminar-based activities across middle and upper grades with documented rubrics, expectations, and outcomes to deepen the classical dialogue model.
- Increase opportunities for public speaking and rhetorical exercises (continuous across grades, not only in upper grades) to reinforce rhetoric training as a core habit.
- Identity strengthening of the classical spine
- Integrate language heritage (Latin/Greek options) and formal grammar/logic/rhetoric sequences as a unified scaffold rather than dispersed, ad-hoc references.
- Provide explicit alignment between Great Books, Classical Liberal Arts, and classroom activities (memory work, narration, discussions) with tangible outcomes and standards.
- Documentation of classical signals in public materials
- Ensure public pages reliably reflect the Trivium framework, Great Books trajectory, and explicit classical pedagogy (in addition to Montessori elements) to reduce ambiguity and strengthen the CLASSICAL signal in Curriculum and Pedagogy.
- Strengthen liturgical and metaphysical coherence
- Maintain and deepen liturgical practices while highlighting how these connect to literary, historical, and moral formation across grades. Provide explicit mappings between liturgical life and curricular themes (truth, goodness, beauty) to reinforce transcendental aims.

Citations for needle-moving items - Classroom Great Books evidence and Shakespeare emphasis; explicit textual references to classical approach; Montessori blend noted in curriculum. - Socratic/seminar potential and rhetoric emphasis in upper grades. - Parent/Community engagement practices.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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